KPPSC PMS • EUROPEAN HISTORY (PAPER I) ## QUESTION 11: THE NATIONAL ASSEMBLY & CONSTITUTIONAL REFORMS (1789–1791)

EXECUTIVE EXAM METADATA - **EXAM QUESTIONS LINKED: 2022 Q.1: "Revolutions often start from the streets but eventually get completed in legislatures.' In the light of this statement, assess the role of the National Assembly in France between 1789 and 1791.' - **SYLLABUS TOPIC:** Paper I — Section 1: The French Revolution — National Constituent Assembly & Constitutional Transformation (1789–1791) - **ALLOCATED MARKS / TIME:** 20 Marks | 35 Minutes | Standard Word Count: ~650–700 words - **HISTORIOGRAPHICAL THESIS:** While insurrectionary street mobilizations in Paris and peasant jacqueries in the countryside broke the coercive apparatus of Bourbon absolutism, it was the legislative craftsmanship of the National Constituent Assembly (1789–1791) that translated raw popular violence into an enduring institutional, administrative, and constitutional reality, proving that while streets dismantle absolute tyranny, legislatures institutionalize modern freedom.**

📌 EXAM ESSENTIAL TAKEAWAY > • The Street-Legislature Dialectic: Popular insurrections (Storming of the Bastille on July 14, Great Fear in the countryside in July–August, Women's March on Versailles on October 5–6) repeatedly rescued the bourgeois National Assembly from royal military repression and forced Louis XVI to yield. > > • The Legislative Miracle: In two years, the National Assembly dismantled over a millennium of feudal institutions: Night of August 4 (abolition of feudal dues and seigneurial courts); Declaration of the Rights of Man and Citizen (August 26, 1789); Civil Constitution of the Clergy (July 1790); and the Constitution of 1791. > > • Rationalized Administrative Architecture: Eradicated the chaotic 300-custom patchwork of the Ancien Régime, dividing France into 83 uniform, self-governing Départements; standardized weights and measures; eliminated internal customs barriers; and instituted trial by jury. > > • Bourgeois Contradiction & Limits: The Assembly restricted the franchise through property qualifications, dividing citizens into 'Active' (tax-paying men with voting rights) and 'Passive' (excluded working classes), sowing the seeds for future radical Jacobin insurrections. >

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1. CONCEPTUAL MIND MAP & THEMATIC PATHWAY ```

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POPULAR PRESSURE (THE STREETS) LEGISLATIVE CODIFICATION (THE ASSEMBLY 1789-1791)

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[July 14: Bastille Stormed] --> [Rescues Assembly; Royal Troops Withdraw from Paris] [July-Aug: Peasant Great Fear] --> [Night of August 4: Decrees Abolish Feudalism & Tithes] [Urban Bread Crisis & Agitation] --> [August 26: Declaration of Rights of Man Codified] [Oct 5-6: Women's March to Versailles]-> [Forces King & Assembly to Paris; Subordinates Crown] [Fiscal Crisis & Sans-Culottes] --> [Nov 1789: Church Property Nationalized (Assignats)] --> [July 1790: Civil Constitution of the Clergy] --> [Sept 1791: Constitution of 1791 (Constitutional Monarchy)]

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2. CHRONOLOGICAL MILESTONES & DIPLOMATIC DATES | Date / Year | Event / Action | Historical & Exam Significance | |---|---|---| | **June 17–20, 1789 | Birth of National Assembly & Tennis Court Oath | Third Estate declares national sovereignty; vows to draft a constitution despite royal lockouts. | | **July 14, 1789** | Fall of the Bastille | Street insurrection destroys royal despotism symbol; forces Louis XVI to recognize the Assembly and wear tricolor. | | **Aug 4, 1789** | Abolition of Feudalism | Assembly deputies renounce aristocratic privileges, hunting rights, tithes, and tax immunities in night session. | | **Aug 26, 1789** | Declaration of the Rights of Man | Foundational charter of human liberty promulgated: equality before law, freedom of speech/religion, property rights. | | **Oct 5–6, 1789** | October Days (Women's March) | 7,000 armed women march to Versailles; bring 'the Baker, the Baker's wife, and the Baker's little boy' to Paris. | | **Nov 2, 1789** | Confiscation of Church Lands | Assembly nationalizes ecclesiastical wealth (biens nationaux) to back paper currency (assignats). | | **July 12, 1790** | Civil Constitution of the Clergy | Priests turned into salaried state officials elected by citizens; creates disastrous religious schism in France. | | **March 1791** | Allarde & Le Chapelier Laws | Assembly abolishes craft guilds and bans workers' trade unions/strikes, enshrining bourgeois free market. | | **June 20, 1791** | Flight to Varennes | Louis XVI attempts to flee abroad to lead counter-revolution; shatters the Assembly's constitutional monarchy illusion. | | **Sept 3–30, 1791** | Constitution of 1791 & Dissolution | First written constitution enacted; Assembly dissolves via Robespierre's Self-Denying Ordinance. |**

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3. THE 20-MARK MASTER MODEL ESSAY (~650 WORDS)

Introduction: The Street-Legislature Dialectic The axiom that 'revolutions often start from the streets but eventually get completed in legislatures' encapsulates the essential dialectic of the French Revolution between 1789 and 1791. Left to themselves, street insurrections and peasant jacqueries represent destructive energies capable of paralyzing an authoritarian regime, yet inherently incapable of constructing a durable institutional order. Conversely, legislative bodies operating in a political vacuum are easily intimidated or dispersed by armed royalist power. Between the summer of 1789 and the autumn of 1791, the French National Constituent Assembly functioned as the institutional crucible of the modern world precisely because it engaged in a symbiotic dialogue with popular street mobilization. While the storming of the Bastille and the October Days shattered the crown's coercive apparatus, it was the jurists, philosophers, and bourgeois deputies of the National Assembly who forged that raw rebellious fury into the constitutional, administrative, and legal foundation of the modern French state.

The Streets as the Armed Protector of the Legislature The National Assembly was born in defiance on June 17, 1789, when the Third Estate, joined by liberal clerics and nobles, proclaimed itself the sovereign representative body of France and took the solemn Tennis Court Oath. However, King Louis XVI immediately concentrated twenty thousand Swiss and German mercenary troops around Paris to crush the nascent parliament. The Assembly was preserved from military dissolution exclusively by the spontaneous intervention of the streets. On July 14, 1789, Parisian artisans, shopkeepers, and wage-earners stormed the Bastille fortress, seizing thirty thousand muskets and lynching Governor de Launay. This street uprising permanently broke the royal monopoly on violence, forced Louis XVI to withdraw his troops, accept the tricolor cockade, and legitimize the National Assembly. Similarly, when rural peasants ignited the 'Great Fear' (Grande Peur) in July and August by burning châteaux and seigneurial debt-registers, the Assembly was compelled to accelerate structural reform. Furthermore, during the October Days of 1789, an armed crowd of Parisian market women marched twelve miles through torrential rain to Versailles, storming the palace and compelling both the royal family and the National Assembly to relocate to Paris under the watchful eye of the sovereign populace.

The Legislative Masterstrokes: Dismantling Feudalism and Codifying Rights Having been shielded by popular force, the National Assembly executed an astonishing legislative revolution. In the historic nocturnal session of August 4, 1789, liberal aristocrats and deputies renounced their ancestral privileges, formally abolishing the feudal regime in its entirety. Feudal personal servitude, seigneurial jurisdictions, aristocratic hunting monopolies, and ecclesiastical tithes were obliterated overnight, establishing absolute legal equality. Three weeks later, on August 26, 1789, the Assembly promulgated the 'Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen.' Drafted by the Marquis de Lafayette with input from Thomas Jefferson, this monumental document codified Enlightenment philosophy into positive law: it affirmed that men are born free and equal in rights, declared private property sacred and inviolable, established liberty, security, and resistance to oppression as fundamental entitlements, and proclaimed that sovereignty resides not in the dynastic person of the king, but essentially in the Nation.

Administrative, Judicial, and Fiscal Restructuring The constructive genius of the National Assembly was most vividly displayed in its comprehensive rationalization of French governance. The archaic, labyrinthine administrative patchwork of bailiwicks, intendancies, and custom zones was swept away and replaced by eighty-three uniform, geographically balanced departments (départements), subdivided into districts and communes, each governed by locally elected councils. In the judicial sphere, hereditary venal magistrate offices were abolished, torture was outlawed, and a unified secular legal system featuring trial by public juries was introduced. To resolve the catastrophic royal debt, the Assembly nationalized all Roman Catholic Church property on November 2, 1789 (biens nationaux), issuing interest-bearing bonds known as assignats. While the assignats eventually succumbed to hyperinflation due to over-issuance, the sale of church lands permanently tied the peasant and bourgeois purchasers to the survival of the revolutionary settlement.

Contradictions, Fractures, and the Bourgeois Limitation Despite its monumental achievements, the National Assembly suffered from fatal contradictions that ultimately undermined its moderate constitutional vision. Guided by bourgeois economic interests, the Assembly passed the Le Chapelier Law (June 1791), which outlawed trade unions and collective strikes, leaving urban wage-earners defenseless against capitalist exploitation. More critically, the Constitution of 1791 betrayed the egalitarian promise of the Declaration of Rights by dividing Frenchmen into 'Active' and 'Passive' citizens. Only affluent men paying direct taxes equivalent to three days of labor were granted voting rights, disenfranchising over three million working-class citizens (sans-culottes). The Assembly's most catastrophic miscalculation, however, was the Civil Constitution of the Clergy (July 1790). By transforming priests into salaried civil servants elected by parishioners and demanding a loyalty oath to the state, the Assembly alienated the Pope, split the French clergy into 'juring' and 'refractory' camps, and ignited a bitter religious civil war across rural France (notably in the Vendée).

Conclusion: The Triumph and Legacy of the Legislative Crucible In conclusion, the history of France between 1789 and 1791 affirms that revolutions require both the disruptive eruption of the street and the institutional codification of the legislature. Without

the storming of the Bastille, the Tennis Court oath would have ended in mass arrests; without the Assembly's systematic drafting of eighty-three departments, the abolition of feudalism, and the Constitution of 1791, the street uprisings would have dissipated into aimless anarchy. Although the Flight to Varennes in June 1791 exposed the impossibility of a constitutional monarchy under Louis XVI and propelled France toward the radical Jacobin Republic, the institutional scaffolding erected by the National Constituent Assembly proved permanent. The administrative, legal, and egalitarian framework codified between 1789 and 1791 survived the Reign of Terror, Napoleon Bonaparte, and the Bourbon Restoration, enduring as the bedrock of modern democratic France.

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4. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL PERSPECTIVES & SCHOLARLY QUOTES | Historian | Analytical Perspective | Exact Quotable Argument | |---|---|---| | **Timothy Tackett | Empirical Transformation of Deputies | 'The deputies of the National Assembly did not arrive in Versailles as radical revolutionaries; it was the intense pressure of the Paris streets and court conspiracies that forged them into legislative transformers.' | | **Simon Schama** | Revisionist Critique of Revolutionary Violence | 'From the very beginning, violence was the motor of the French Revolution... the National Assembly legislated under the perpetual shadow of the pike and the lantern.' | | **Albert Soboul** | Marxist Perspective on Bourgeois Hegemony | 'The work of the National Constituent Assembly was essentially a bourgeois triumph; it swept away feudalism to establish the juridical equality necessary for agrarian and commercial capitalism.' | | **William Doyle** | Administrative Legacy of 1789-1791 | 'The destruction of the Ancien Régime was completed in 1789, but the lasting achievement of the National Assembly was the creation of a rational, uniform, and decentralized administrative state.' |**
